

“Eroica,” which premiered in 1805, is often taken as the initiation of a new musical era. It was far longer than any previous symphony, but also more complex, vigorous, and emotionally draining.

His expansion of the possibilities of orchestral writing continued with the tragic and triumphant Fifth Symphony (1808) and the irrepressibly energetic Seventh Symphony (1812). The three “Razumovsky” String Quartets of 1806 carried his new range and ambition into chamber music. For the piano, peaks included the “Waldstein” and “Appassionata” Sonatas (1804 and 1807) and the “Emperor” Concerto (1811). Although initial response to his works varied—his only opera, *Fidelio*, was coolly received in 1805—Beethoven benefited from the open-minded enthusiasm of his Viennese public and patrons.

Fame and status

The first composer to think of himself as an artistic genius, Beethoven did not accept the lowly place in the social hierarchy traditionally accorded to even the most gifted musicians. In his dealings with the upper class, he bluntly refused to observe the usual deference and in 1806 had a violent quarrel with Prince Lichnowsky that ended their relationship. Yet, just like earlier composers, he continued to thrive on the generosity of the music-besotted liberal Viennese aristocracy. In 1808, a group of them clubbed together to provide him with a generous annuity—an income for life.

“You who **think** or **say** that I am **malevolent**, **stubborn**, or **misanthropic**, how **greatly** do